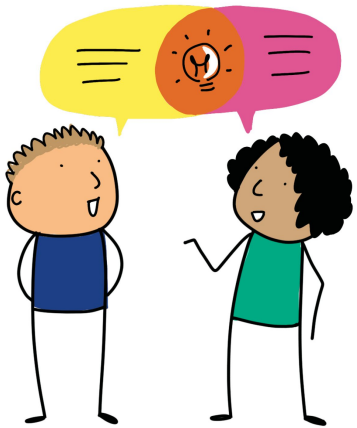
Liberating Structures: What, So What, Now What?

A collection of practical tips, tweaks, and resources



Introduction

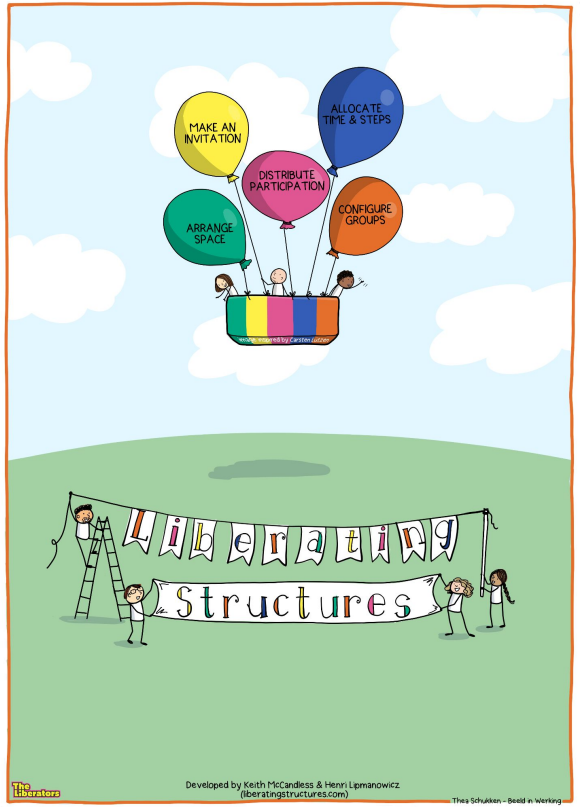
For almost a decade, Liberating Structures have been an important part of my facilitation toolkit. Over the years, I've created my own materials, enjoyed using those created by others, picked up countless practical tips, and discovered many useful tweaks.

Until now, all of these were scattered across different places, often leaving me searching for that one illustration, idea, or tip when I needed it most. So I decided to bring everything together in one place, with a separate guide for each Liberating Structure. And yes, it definitely satisfies my inner facilitation nerd. 🤓

I'm creating these guides mostly for myself, and they'll probably never be finished. I keep learning, experimenting, and discovering new things. But since sharing freely with the community is an important part of what we do, I'll also make them available through [our public GitHub repository](#).

I hope you'll find something useful in them too. Enjoy!

[Barry Overeem](#)



Liberating Structures were developed by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. The foundational Liberating Structures materials are shared under a Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 license (CC BY-SA 4.0).

These Practice Guides build on their work and combine it with our own experiences, illustrations, and practical tips.

The Liberators

About What, So What, Now What?

“What, So What, Now What?” is a Liberating Structure that helps people reflect on experiences, make sense of complex situations, and decide what to do next. In about 30–45 minutes, everyone gets the opportunity to contribute their observations, interpretations, and ideas for action.

Participants move through three simple questions. First, “What?” invites them to look at the facts: What happened? What did you notice? Next, “So What?” focuses on making sense of those observations: Why does this matter? What patterns or insights emerge? Finally, “Now What?” turns reflection into action: What should we do next?

The sequence of these questions is an important part of the structure. Groups often jump quickly from an experience to conclusions or solutions. “What, So What, Now What?” slows that process down. It separates observation from interpretation and interpretation from action, giving people space to first establish what happened before deciding what it means and what to do about it.

Instead of having one person evaluate what happened or decide what should change, everyone contributes to the reflection. Different perspectives become visible, assumptions can be examined, and actions emerge from a shared understanding. Used regularly, “What, So What, Now What?” can turn reflection into a collective habit and help groups translate experience into meaningful action.

Purposes

- **Create shared understanding.** Bring different perspectives together, distinguish observations from interpretations, and develop a richer understanding of what happened.

- **Turn experiences into learning.** Reflect on shared experiences, discover meaningful insights, and identify opportunities to improve rather than repeating the same mistakes.

- **Slow down before taking action.** Resist the temptation to jump straight to solutions. First explore what happened and why it matters before deciding what to do next.

- **Make assumptions visible.** Help participants recognize how their interpretations, beliefs, and assumptions influence the conclusions they draw and the actions they take.

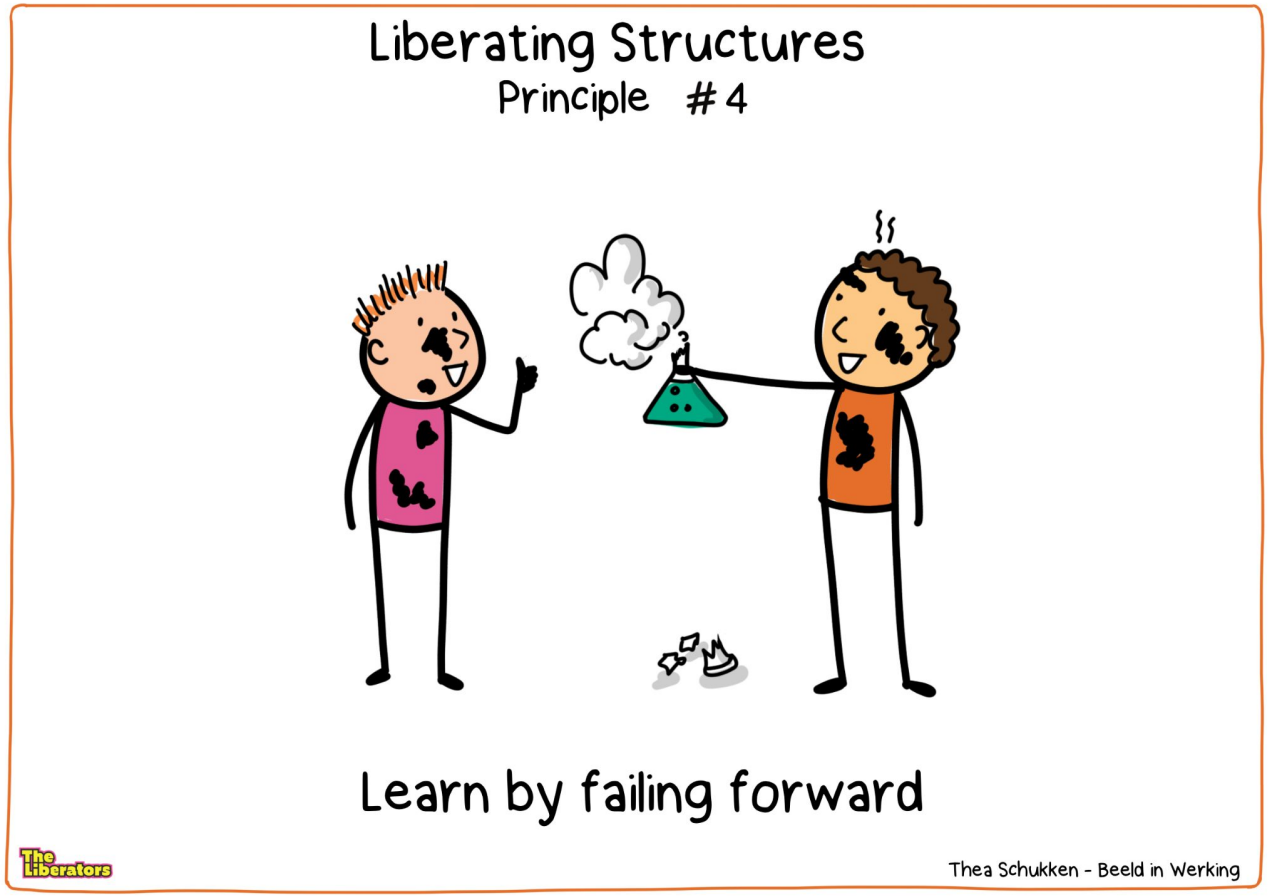
- **Turn reflection into meaningful action.** Translate insights into concrete next steps, experiments, or changes that people can put into practice.

- **Develop a habit of collective reflection.** Make reflection a regular part of how teams work, learn, and improve together rather than something that only happens after problems occur.

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What, So What, Now What enlivens Liberating Structures principle #4

Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]



The Liberators

Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]

What, So What, Now What? - Worksheet

Create shared understanding and decide how to move forward

What?

What do we notice?



So What?

So what does this mean?



Now What?

Now what actions make sense?



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Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz
(liberatingstructures.com)

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]

What?

Step 1 of "What, So What, Now What?"

- What do we notice?
- What do we hear, see, and observe?
- What facts stand out?



Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz
(liberatingstructures.com)

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

So What?

Step 2 of "What, So What, Now What?"

- So what does this mean?
- So what patterns do we notice?
- So what conclusions can we draw?



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Now What?

Step 3 of "What, So What, Now What?"

- Now what actions make sense?
- Now where do we go from here?
- Now what should we invest in?



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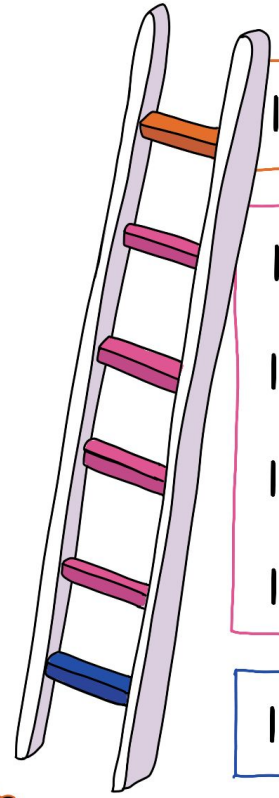
Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]

"What, So What, Now What?" takes inspiration from the Ladder of Inference by Chris Argyris, an expert on learning in organizations.

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The Ladder Of Inference

Create a shared understanding with the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What?"



I take actions based on beliefs  Now What?

I adopt beliefs about the world

I draw conclusions from assumptions

So What?

I make assumptions based on meaning 

I add cultural & personal meaning

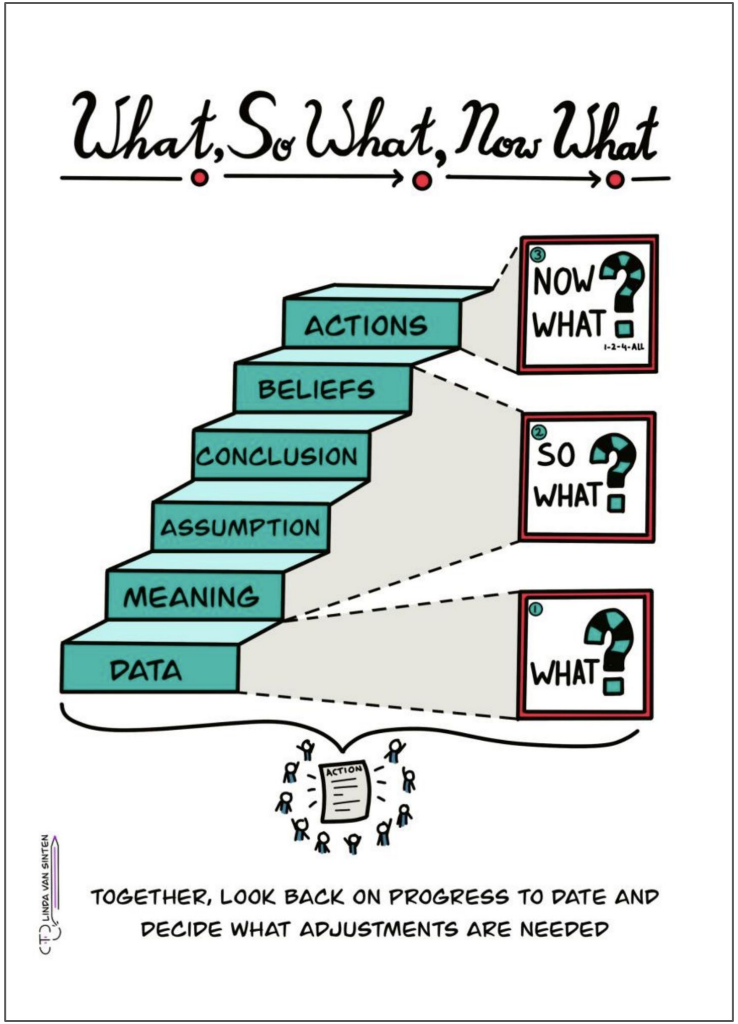
I select data from observations  What?

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Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz.
Based on work by Chris Argyris.

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

Illustration by
[Linda van Sinten]



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Tips & tweaks

- **Clarify the purpose of each question.** Help participants distinguish between observations (“What?”), interpretation (“So What?”), and action (“Now What?”).
- **Choose a clear focus.** Be explicit about what participants are reflecting on, so everyone answers the three questions with the same focus in mind.
- **Protect the sequence.** Don’t allow the group to jump ahead. If interpretations appear during “What?”, park them for “So What?”. If solutions appear during “So What?”, save them for “Now What?”.
- **Harvest one insight at a time.** When returning to the whole group, invite one important insight at a time rather than collecting reports from each group. Look for unique, meaningful contributions and avoid repetition.
- **Optionally, insert a “What If?” question.** Use it between “So What?” and “Now What?” to explore possibilities and generate ideas for experiments.

Tips & tweaks

- **Be particularly strict during “What?”.** Encourage participants to stay with facts, observations, and things they actually noticed rather than explanations or judgments.
- **Use the Ladder of Inference when people struggle with the distinction.** It can help explain why W3 deliberately separates observable data from meaning, conclusions, and action.
- **Don’t rush “So What?”.** This is where the group looks for patterns, surprises, tensions, and possible explanations. Moving too quickly to action can make the reflection superficial.
- **Make “Now What?” actionable.** Encourage small, concrete next steps rather than broad intentions. 15% Solutions can be a useful way to identify actions people can take immediately without needing additional resources or permission.
- **Capture key points visibly.** Use three flip charts or large sheets labeled “What?”, “So What?”, and “Now What?” so participants can see how observations develop into insights and actions.
- **Practice W3 regularly.** The more often you use it, the more natural it becomes. Eventually, moving from observation to interpretation to action will feel almost like breathing.

Combo's

- **Integrate 1-2-4-All into the exercise.** Use it to help everyone contribute to each of the three questions before harvesting the most important insights with the whole group.
- **Make reflection more concrete with Ecocycle Planning.** Use it to visualize patterns emerging from W3 and identify activities that need attention, renewal, or change.
- **Follow W3 with Troika Consulting or Wise Crowds.** Use the insights and challenges that emerge from W3 as input for peer consultation, helping participants explore possible actions and solutions.
- **Combine W3 with Impromptu Networking.** Use three rounds of conversations with different partners, exploring "What?", "So What?", and "Now What?" in successive rounds.
- **Combine W3 with Conversation Café.** Use the three questions to guide a deeper conversation, drawing on Conversation Café's structured rounds and talking object to ensure everyone has a chance to contribute.
- **Combine W3 with Spiral Journal.** Use Spiral Journal during "What?" to help participants slow down, ground themselves, and capture concrete observations through their senses. In the final quadrant, invite them to reflect on how these observations make them feel.

When to use it?

- **Reflect on a shared experience.** Use W3 after a meeting, workshop, event, or project to explore what happened, make sense of it, and decide what to do next.
- **Run a Retrospective.** Help teams reflect on their recent Sprint, identify meaningful patterns, and agree on improvements.
- **Make sense of a complex situation.** Bring different perspectives together to better understand what is happening before deciding how to respond.
- **Learn from an experiment.** Explore what happened, what surprised you, and what you might try differently next time.
- **Reflect on personal experiences.** Use W3 individually to make sense of an experience, discover insights, and identify next steps.
- **Make sense of a conflict.** Help people separate what actually happened from their interpretations, explore different perspectives, and identify constructive ways forward.

Online tips

- **Share the three questions on screen.** Keep “What?”, “So What?”, and “Now What?” visible so participants always know which step they are working on.
- **Put the instructions in the chat.** This is especially useful when participants work in breakout rooms and can no longer see your slides.
- **Use a shared digital workspace to capture observations and insights.** Tools like a shared document or whiteboard make it easier to see patterns across the group.
- **Give participants quiet individual reflection time before discussing each question.** Online conversations can quickly be dominated by the fastest voices.
- **Explain the full process before opening breakout rooms.** If groups move through all three steps independently, make sure the questions, timing, and sequence are clear beforehand.
- **Avoid sending too many messages into breakout rooms.** They can easily interrupt the conversation. Limit reminders to important transitions or timing cues.

Template for drafting a memorandum

Based on Nadia von Holzen's story in the book "LS Stories from the Field", page 167, chapter: "Distilling insights towards shared direction.

What?

Data, facts, observations

- We acknowledge…
- We see…
- We take note of…
- We observe…

So what?

Conclusions, beliefs, assumptions

- We conclude…
- We infer…
- We deduce…
- We figure…

Now what?

Actions, improvements, recommendations

- We take action on…
- We call up on…
- We move forwards…
- We take the initiative…

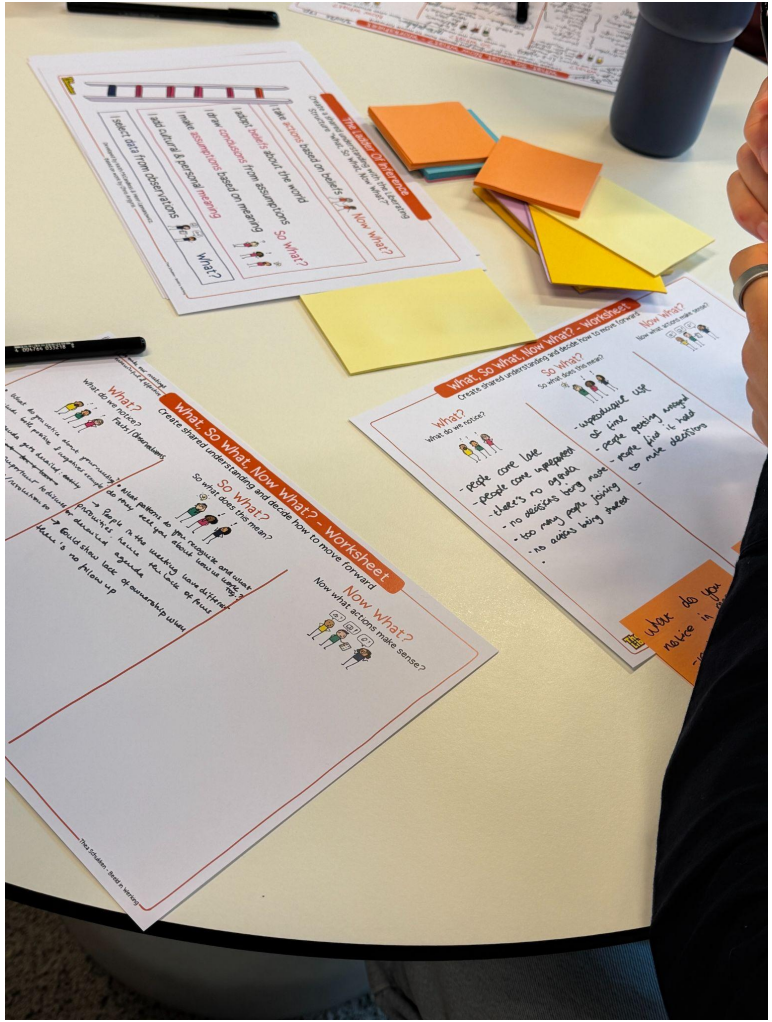
The Liberators

“What, So What, Now What?”
in action



The Liberators

“What, So What, Now What?” in action



Interested in learning more?

Articles about What, So What, Now What?:

- Our thoughts on this Liberating Structure
- Use W3 during the Sprint Retrospective
- The official description of What, So What, Now What?

Looking for (even) more inspiration?

- Check the resources on the Liberating Structures website
- Check our blog with 100+ articles
- Download the LiSA app by Holisticon
- Browse our public GitHub repository with illustrations, DIY workshops, templates, papers, and other free resources.
- Here's the webshop with Linda van Sinten's illustrations
- Join our public online or in-person meetups

Interested in collaborating?

- Check my workshop offerings.
- I'm available as a trainer or facilitator for meetings, workshops, and other gatherings.
- Whether you want to learn Liberating Structures or use them to tackle a real challenge, I'd be happy to help.

Get in touch: barry.overeem@theliberators.com



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Unleashing Organisational Superpowers